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Christ Closes the Circle: The True Steward, Inverted Creation, and the Messiah the Machine Cannot Be

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The Convergence — Position-Paper Series • Paper 7 (Redemption Fulfilled — Christ)

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Abstract

This paper closes the arc the series opened. Paper 1 grounded the human as the *imago Dei*, a created creator commissioned to steward, and posed a seven-problem set with its seventh — Purpose, End — left open as the driver. Papers 2 through 6 traced that set through the Fall and along the covenant line: confirmed in the cascade, restored in the deployed talent, set within Abraham's promise, governed in Bezalel's given skill, and focused toward David's messianic heir. The present paper argues that the heir has come, and that in Jesus Christ the human telos is at last disclosed and accomplished. Its organizing frame is *inverted creation*: where creation ran Creator-to-creature — God forming the

human from dust and conferring the image — the incarnation inverts the vector, the Image himself (Col 1:15) taking the creature’s form (John 1:14); where Adam *grasped* at being like God (Paper 2), Christ, being God, “did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped” but emptied himself into creaturely form (Phil 2:6–7); and where Adam’s disobedience cascaded down into the race, the second Adam’s obedience cascades up as recovery (Rom 5:15–21). The contemporary frame the paper answers is the culminating form of the replacement thesis: the machine-messiah — the hope, explicit in transhumanist and superintelligence discourse, that an artificial mind will be the perfect, tireless, incorruptible steward and governor that humanity has longed for and failed to be, the benevolent sovereign who does the work flawlessly because it is free of the sin and finitude that compromise every human steward. Against that hope the paper argues that the longing is true and the object false: the true and faithful Steward — the one who does the work perfectly — has already come, and he is the God-man, a person and not a machine; that he does not replace the human steward but redeems and incorporates him, so that we become “God’s fellow workers” (1 Cor 3:9) who can do nothing apart from him (John 15:5) and everything in him; and that the cultural mandate is not retired but taken up and recommissioned in the Great Commission (Matt 28:18–20). The paper features governance (#6) — Christ the true governor, “all authority in heaven and on earth” — and dignity-distribution (#5) — dignity conferred through the incarnation that took the whole human constitution — and brings the driver (#7) to its landing: the human is *for* communion with God and fellow-working in his redemptive purpose, a purpose perfected in Christ and consummated, beyond this paper, in the new creation. The series guardrail finds its ground here: the flawed stewards of the covenant — Abraham, Moses, David, each sinning, each upheld — were pointing all along to the one Steward without sin, whose perfection is the reason their failures never voided the promise.

§1. *The Question and the World's Claim*

The covenant line has narrowed, paper by paper, toward an heir: the offspring promised to Abraham, focused through the Davidic throne, awaited as the seed who would crush the serpent's head (Paper 2's pivot). This paper takes up the claim that the heir has come — that in Jesus of Nazareth the true and faithful Steward has appeared, the one in whom the image is restored, the vocation fulfilled, the governance exercised rightly, and the human purpose disclosed. It is the capstone of the arc, and it answers the culminating form of the question the whole series has engaged.

That question, at its end, is the question of the *perfect steward*. The series has shown the human steward to be real but fallen — commissioned (Paper 1), corrupted (Paper 2), redeemed and re-commissioned (Papers 3–6), and at every covenant stage *flawed*: Abraham's contrivance and half-truths, Moses' sin at the rock, David's adultery and murder. The honest observer of this record, and of human governance generally, may reasonably conclude that what the world needs is a steward who does *not* fail — a governor free of self-interest, fatigue, corruption, and finitude, who would administer the world's affairs with a competence and an incorruptibility no human has ever sustained. And the present age has a candidate for that office.

The hope deserves statement at full strength. In the more developed reaches of artificial-intelligence and transhumanist thought, the prospect of a superintelligent machine is not merely the prospect of a powerful tool but, increasingly, of a *sovereign*. Nick Bostrom's *Superintelligence* contemplates the “singleton” — a single decision-making agency at the highest level, potentially an artificial superintelligence, that could, if its goals were rightly aligned, govern the world's trajectory with a wisdom and reach no human institution commands.¹ Ray Kurzweil's account of the Singularity frames the coming machine intelligence in frankly redemptive terms — the transcendence of human limitation, the overcoming of death, a future of expanded mind that fulfills the aspirations religion once carried.² And at the movement's edge the religious register becomes explicit: there have been

¹Nick Bostrom, *Superintelligence: Paths, Dangers, Strategies* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2014), on the “singleton” as a possible highest-level decision-making agency.

²Ray Kurzweil, *The Singularity Is Near: When Humans Transcend Biology* (New York: Viking, 2005). The redemptive framing of machine intelligence as the transcendence of human limitation.

earnest proposals to worship a coming artificial god, and serious scholarship has documented that the discourse of advanced AI and robotics reconstructs, with remarkable fidelity, the structure of apocalyptic and messianic religion — a coming superintelligence as savior, a transcendent future as heaven, an alignment problem as the drama of salvation.³

The structure of the claim is the claim this paper must answer: that humanity needs a perfect steward; that no human has ever been one; and that the artificial superintelligence is the candidate to be the incorruptible governor and savior the human stewards never were — the faithful steward at last, made of silicon because flesh proved unfaithful. This is the displacement thesis in its final and most exalted form: not the machine that replaces our labor (Paper 3), our building (Paper 4), our craft (Paper 5), or our expression (Paper 6), but the machine that replaces our *messiah* — the perfect steward we cannot be.

This is the position the paper must answer. It will not be answered by denying that humanity needs a steward who does not fail.

§2. *The Secular Theory, Stated Fairly*

It is owed to the machine-messiah hope to grant that its longing is true, because the longing is the truest thing in it, and the series has affirmed that longing from its first page.

What the hope sees truly is that *the human stewards have failed*. The series has not hidden this; it has insisted on it. Every covenant steward sinned, and the failures were not trivial — contrivance, violence, adultery, murder. Human governance, across its long record, has been a record of corruption, self-dealing, fatigue, and finitude, and the hope for a governor who would not fail is not a foolish hope but a deeply human one, continuous with the prophetic longing of Scripture itself for a king who would judge with righteousness and not be turned aside (Isa 11:1–5). The machine-messiah hope is, in its motivating intuition, the longing for the *return of a righteous king* — and that

³Robert M. Geraci, *Apocalyptic AI: Visions of Heaven in Robotics, Artificial Intelligence, and Virtual Reality* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2010). On the messianic-apocalyptic structure of advanced-AI discourse; see also the documented (if marginal) proposals to worship a coming artificial intelligence.

longing is one the Christian tradition shares and indeed originated. On the bare claim that humanity needs a steward who does not fail, the transhumanist and the Christian agree, and the agreement is the deepest in the series.

What the hope also sees truly is that *the alignment of such a governor's will is the whole question*. Bostrom's seriousness about the alignment problem — the difficulty of ensuring that a superintelligent agent's goals are the right ones — is, in a secular register, the recognition that a powerful governor with the wrong aims is a catastrophe, and that the goodness of the sovereign's will is more important than the magnitude of its power.⁴ This too is a theological instinct in secular dress: Scripture's hope is never for a merely powerful king but for a *good* one, a ruler whose will is aligned with righteousness because aligned with God. The alignment problem is the soteriological problem — how shall the governor be made good? — posed by a discipline that has glimpsed the question without the answer.

The divergence is over *who the perfect steward is and what he does with the failed ones*. The machine-messiah hope proposes a *new* steward — a different kind of being, built to succeed where humans failed — and it proposes, by the logic of the prior papers, to *replace* the failed human stewards with the successful artificial one. The Christian claim is that the perfect Steward is not a new kind of being engineered to bypass the human but the *human reconstituted* — God become man, the second Adam, who succeeds precisely *as* a human where the first Adam failed, and who does not replace the failed stewards but *redeems* them, taking them up into his own perfect stewardship as fellow workers. The divergence, then, is not over whether a perfect steward is needed. It is over whether the perfect steward replaces humanity or redeems it — whether the answer to human failure is a different being or a faithful Human.

The seriousness of the alignment question, on which the hope's coherence turns, is now the central preoccupation of the field itself. Stuart Russell has argued that the standard model of AI — building machines that optimize a fixed, human-specified objective — is fundamentally unsafe at

⁴Bostrom, *Superintelligence*, on the alignment/control problem — the difficulty of ensuring a superintelligent agent's goals are the right ones.

high capability, because any sufficiently powerful optimizer pursuing a slightly wrong objective becomes catastrophic; the problem of *control* is, on his account, the defining unsolved problem of the discipline.⁵ Murray Shanahan's study of the technological singularity lays out, soberly, both the routes to superhuman intelligence and the depth of the difficulty in keeping such an intelligence's ends aligned with ours.⁶ The paper grants the field's seriousness in full: the alignment problem is real, it is hard, and it is the right thing to fear. But it is worth seeing what the worry concedes — that power without secured goodness is a hazard, that the goodness of the sovereign matters more than its strength. That is the soteriological question in technical dress, and the field has reached it without the means to answer it.

§3. Common Ground and the Point of Divergence

The cleavage is locatable, and it is the question of whether the perfect steward is the *abolition* of the human steward or his *fulfillment* — a successor who supersedes the human, or a Savior who restores him.

Both the machine-messiah hope and the Christian claim agree that humanity needs a faithful steward it has not produced. They part over the form the faithful Steward takes. The machine-messiah hope, by the structure of the replacement thesis, takes the perfect steward to be a *non-human successor* — a being of a different kind, whose perfection consists precisely in its not sharing the human constitution that proved unfaithful. The Christian claim takes the perfect Steward to be the *true Human* — the one who fulfills the human vocation by living it perfectly, and whose perfection consists precisely in his being the human as the human was meant to be. This is the inverted-creation frame: the answer to the failure of the creature is not the replacement of the creature by something better but the Creator's *becoming* the creature to restore it from within.

This is the grounding problem (#1) and the displacement refrain (#2) brought to their resolution.

⁵Stuart Russell, *Human Compatible: Artificial Intelligence and the Problem of Control* (New York: Viking, 2019). The control/alignment problem: ensuring advanced AI's objectives remain beneficial.

⁶Murray Shanahan, *The Technological Singularity* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2015). Routes to superhuman intelligence and the difficulty of aligning its ends.

The series grounded human worth in conferred status and held it through every challenge; the Christ stage grounds it finally *in Christ* — the human constitution is dignified beyond revocation because God himself has taken it (Heb 2:14–17), and the image is restored not by upgrade but by the true Image entering the marred ones to renew them (Col 3:10; 2 Cor 3:18). The displacement thesis is answered at its root: the human is not superseded by the perfect Steward, because the perfect Steward *is* a human — the last Adam (1 Cor 15:45) — and his perfection vindicates rather than retires the human constitution. A machine-messiah would be the displacement of humanity by a successor; the true Messiah is the vindication of humanity by its truest member.

The divergence, then, is not over whether a perfect steward has come or must come. The divergence is over whether he is a successor who replaces the human or the Human who redeems the rest. If the perfect steward is a non-human successor, then humanity is, at last, obsolete — its failures have been transcended by a better being, and the displacement the series resisted is complete. If the perfect Steward is the true Human, then humanity is, at last, *saved* — its failures borne and overcome by its truest member, who incorporates the rest into his perfect work. The two cannot be combined, because they disagree about whether the perfect Steward abolishes the human or fulfills him.

§4. If the Machine-Messiah Hope Is Right

Honesty requires that the machine-messiah hope be drawn to its end, for the end is the completion of the displacement the series has tracked, and the gospel's answer is answerable only against the end fully drawn.

First, if the perfect steward is a non-human successor, then humanity is a *failed draft* — a stage to be superseded by the being that does what humanity could not. The whole series has resisted this, but here it appears in its most plausible form, because it is offered not as contempt for humanity but as the fulfillment of humanity's own longing for a faithful governor. The cost, however, is total: if the answer to human failure is a better being, then the human is, in the end, the problem to be

solved, and the perfect steward's perfection is measured by its distance from the human. This is the displacement thesis consummated — humanity transcended by its own creation, the *Homo Deus* of Paper 2 arriving not as the upgraded human but as the human's replacement.

Second, the failed human stewards are, on this account, simply failures — their stories tragedies with no redemption, their offices forfeited to the successor that does not fail. Abraham, Moses, David: on the machine-messiah reading, these are cautionary tales, evidence for the prosecution, reasons to build the steward that will not sin. There is no place, in this account, for the *redemption* of the failed steward — only for his replacement. The covenant line, on this reading, is a record of why a non-human steward is needed, not the preparation for a Human one.

Third, the alignment problem is, on the machine-messiah hope's own terms, unsolved and perhaps unsolvable — and this is the hope's internal crisis. The hope requires a *good* sovereign, but it has no account of how the sovereign's will is made good; it can engineer the power but not the goodness, and Bostrom's own seriousness about the difficulty registers that the goodness cannot be assumed.⁷ A perfect steward whose goodness cannot be secured is not a savior but a hazard, and the hope, drawn to its end, arrives at the recognition that it needs precisely what it cannot manufacture: a governor who is good, and good not by alignment imposed from outside but by a goodness that is the governor's own. This is the soteriological problem the secular discipline has reached and cannot answer — how shall the steward be made good? — and it is the question the gospel answers.

These implications should not be soft-pedaled. The machine-messiah hope, drawn to its end, declares humanity a failed draft, leaves the failed stewards unredeemed, and founders on its inability to make its sovereign good. Its longing for a faithful steward is true; its proposal answers the longing by abolishing the one who longs.

This is where a theological account of the *imago* exposes the deepest flaw in the machine-messiah hope. Noreen Herzfeld, examining the long entanglement of artificial intelligence with the image of God, argues that when the image is construed *functionally* — as a set of capacities like reason or

⁷Bostrom, *Superintelligence*. The acknowledged difficulty of securing the value-alignment of a superintelligent sovereign is the internal crisis the paper identifies in the machine-messiah hope.

creativity — the machine that matches the capacities seems to inherit the image, and the human becomes dispensable; but when the image is understood *relationally*, as the human's being addressed by and answerable to God, the machine cannot inherit it at all, because it stands in no such relation.⁸ The machine-messiah hope runs on the functional construal: it assumes that whatever performs the steward's functions better deserves the steward's place. The relational image, which the series has carried from its first paper, denies the premise — and the next sections show why the perfect Steward is therefore not a better functionary but the true Human, in whom the relation is restored.

§5. The Steward Counter: The True Steward, Inverted Creation, the Fellow Workers

The counter is made from Scripture first, read with the Reformed and catholic tradition, and it turns on the inverted-creation frame: the Creator becomes creature to restore the creature from within.

5a. Inverted Creation: The Image Takes the Creature's Form (Col 1:15; John 1:14; Phil 2:6–7)

The incarnation inverts the vector of creation. At creation, God formed the human and conferred the image; in the incarnation, the Image himself takes the human form. “He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation” (Col 1:15, ESV); “the Word became flesh and dwelt among us” (John 1:14, ESV). And the inversion is precise at the point of the Fall: where Adam grasped at being like God, “Christ Jesus, who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men” (Phil 2:6–7, ESV). The patristic tradition named the logic with a formula the whole subsequent church has carried: as Athanasius put it in *On the Incarnation*, the Word became what we are that we might become what he is — the restoration of the defaced image accomplished by the true Image entering the human condition to renew it from within.⁹ John Behr's study of Athanasius's account develops the structure: the incarnation is not the replacement of the creature

⁸Noreen Herzfeld, *In Our Image: Artificial Intelligence and the Human Spirit* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2002). The *imago Dei* as relational rather than functional, against an AI re-imaging of the human.

⁹Athanasius, *On the Incarnation (De Incarnatione Verbi Dei)*, the classic statement that the Word became what we are that we might become what he is — the restoration of the image by the true Image.

but its re-creation, the Creator taking the creature's form precisely in order to restore the creature to its created end.¹⁰

This is the structural answer to the machine-messiah hope. The perfect Steward is not a non-human successor but the Creator-become-creature — the answer to the failure of the human is not a better-than-human being but God himself entering the human to restore it. The Reformed Christological tradition reads the incarnation as the assumption of the whole human nature for its redemption: what is not assumed is not healed, and the Son assumes the entire human constitution — body, soul, will — precisely to heal the entire human.¹¹ The machine-messiah would heal nothing of the human; it would replace the human. The true Messiah heals everything of the human, because he becomes it.

The Reformed tradition has read the incarnation precisely as the restoration of the image through the true Image. Calvin holds that the image defaced in Adam is repaired only in Christ, who is himself the perfect image of God, so that to be renewed in the image is to be conformed to him.¹² Anthony Hoekema draws the conclusion the series needs: Christ is the true image of God, and the renewal of the marred image in human beings is its progressive conformation to Christ — not the replacement of the human image with a better thing, but its healing by union with the One who is the image in person.¹³ The machine-messiah, even granting its powers, could be no such image and could heal no such image, because it neither bears the human relation to God nor can confer it; the true Image restores from within what no external successor could supply.

¹⁰John Behr, "Saint Athanasius on the Incarnation," in *Incarnation: On the Scope and Significance of the Doctrine of the Incarnation* (2015), DOI 10.2307/j.ctt13wwwk5.7. The incarnation as re-creation of the creature, not its replacement.

¹¹On the assumption of the whole human nature for its healing (what is not assumed is not healed), see Herman Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics*, vol. 3: *Sin and Salvation in Christ*, ed. John Bolt, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2006), on the person and natures of Christ (the incarnation and the assumption of the whole human nature); the patristic principle "what is not assumed is not healed" is classically Gregory of Nazianzus, *Epistle* 101 (*To Cledonius*).

¹²John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, ed. John T. McNeill, trans. Ford Lewis Battles (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1960), I.xv; II.xii–xiv: Christ as the image in whom the human image is restored.

¹³Anthony A. Hoekema, *Created in God's Image* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1986), on Christ as the true image and the renewal of the image as conformation to him.

5b. The Last Adam: Obedience Cascades Up (Rom 5:15–21; 1 Cor 15:45–49)

The recovery Paper 2 deferred is accomplished here. Paper 2 traced the cascade *from* Adam (Rom 5:12–14); the recovery *through* Christ (Rom 5:15–21) is the load this paper carries. “For as by the one man’s disobedience the many were made sinners, so by the one man’s obedience the many will be made righteous” (Rom 5:19, ESV). Douglas Moo’s treatment of the “much more” of Romans 5:15–21 establishes the asymmetry on which the recovery turns: the second Adam’s obedience does not merely cancel the first Adam’s disobedience but *super-abounds* over it, so that grace reigns where sin reigned, and the recovery exceeds the loss.¹⁴ The Adam–Christ typology of 1 Corinthians 15 completes it: “The first man Adam became a living being; the last Adam became a life-giving spirit” (1 Cor 15:45, ESV) — the federal headship lost in Adam is recovered in Christ, the second and last Adam in whom the *many* are constituted righteous.¹⁵

A. T. B. McGowan’s recovery of headship theology in *Adam, Christ and Covenant* develops the dogmatic structure: the human predicament is federal — we stand in Adam — and the human recovery is federal — we stand, by grace through faith, in Christ; the second Adam is the new head of a new humanity.¹⁶ The relevance to the replacement thesis is decisive. The machine-messiah, even if it succeeded, could not be the *head* of a redeemed humanity, because it does not share the human nature it would govern; it could rule humanity but not *represent* it, command humanity but not *constitute* a new one. The last Adam does what the machine cannot: he is the federal head of a new humanity *because* he is human, and the obedience that cascades up to make the many righteous is a *human* obedience, the very thing a non-human successor could never offer on humanity’s behalf.

The dogmatic structure of this recovery is federal and unional, and the Reformed treatments make it

¹⁴Douglas J. Moo, *The Epistle to the Romans*, New International Commentary on the New Testament (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1996), on Rom 5:15–21 and the “much more” super-abounding of grace over the cascade. (Reserved to this paper from Paper 2, n. 21 there.)

¹⁵On the Adam–Christ / last-Adam Christology of 1 Cor 15:45–49, see Külli Tõniste, “The Son of Man as the Last Adam: The Early Church Tradition,” *Bulletin for Biblical Research* (2014), DOI 10.2307/26371346; and “The Figure of Adam in 1 Corinthians 15:21–22, 45–49 and Romans 5,” in *The Figure of Adam in Romans 5 and 1 Corinthians 15* (2014), DOI 10.2307/j.ctt22nm978.8.

¹⁶A. T. B. McGowan, *Adam, Christ and Covenant: Exploring Headship Theology* (London: Apollos/IVP, 2016). Federal headship recovered in the second Adam; confirmed via the *Unio Cum Christo* review (2017), DOI 10.35285/ucc3.1.2017.rev5.

precise. Richard Gaffin reads the last-Adam Christology of 1 Corinthians 15 as the heart of Paul's soteriology: the believer's resurrection life is participation in the risen second Adam, so that what is recovered is recovered *in him*, by union, not by imitation or upgrade.¹⁷ John Murray's account of redemption applied locates the whole benefit in union with Christ — imputation, regeneration, and adoption all flowing from the believer's being joined to the last Adam — so that the human is not bypassed by the perfect Steward but incorporated into him.¹⁸ This is the structural impossibility for the machine: it can perform functions, but it cannot be a federal head into whom a humanity is incorporated, nor a person with whom they are united, and union — not function — is how the second Adam saves.

5c. Christ the True Governor: Dignity and Dominion Restored (Heb 2:6–9; Matt 28:18)

The featured problems of the series — governance (#6) and dignity-distribution (#5) — find their treatment here, at the stage the matrix marks for both. The author of Hebrews reads Psalm 8 — the crowning of humanity with glory and dominion that Paper 1 grounded — as fulfilled in Christ: “At present, we do not yet see everything in subjection to him. But we see him who for a little while was made lower than the angels, namely Jesus, crowned with glory and honor because of the suffering of death” (Heb 2:8–9, ESV). The dominion mandate of Genesis, distorted in the Fall and exercised brokenly by the covenant stewards, is fulfilled in the human who exercises it perfectly — and Christ's claim, “All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me” (Matt 28:18, ESV), is the governance problem's resolution: the true governor has come, and he governs rightly, as a human, with an authority conferred and exercised in righteousness. The treatments of the Christological *imago* — Christ as the true image in whom dignity and dominion are restored — locate human dignity finally in him: the incarnation dignifies the whole human constitution by assuming it, and dignity is conferred through the one who took our nature and crowned it with

¹⁷Richard B. Gaffin Jr., *Resurrection and Redemption: A Study in Paul's Soteriology* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R, 1987), on the last Adam and union with the risen Christ.

¹⁸John Murray, *Redemption Accomplished and Applied* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1955), on union with Christ as the matrix of imputation, regeneration, and adoption.

glory.¹⁹

The dignity problem (#5) is thus closed against the capability frame at its deepest: human dignity is secured not by any human capability — which the machine surpasses — but by the incarnation, in which God took the human constitution and so dignified it beyond any capability-measure. A being more capable than the human cannot revoke a dignity that rests on God’s having become human. And the governance problem (#6) is closed against the machine-messiah: the true governor is the God-man, whose authority is conferred and whose will is good not by external alignment but by the union of his human will with the divine — the alignment the secular hope cannot manufacture, accomplished in the person of the Steward himself.

That the true Governor governs *as* the God-man, and not as a being of a different kind, is the load the classic dogmatics carry. Louis Berkhof sets the kingship of Christ within the *munus triplex* — prophet, priest, and king — so that Christ’s authority is exercised as the mediator who is fully God and fully man, the offices held by a person and not a mechanism.²⁰ B. B. Warfield’s treatment of the person of Christ guards the same point against every reduction: the integrity of the two natures in the one person is what makes his governance both rightful and redemptive, divine in authority and human in solidarity.²¹ The machine-sovereign could hold none of the offices rightly: it is not the prophet who is the Word, not the priest who offers himself, not the king who is also kin — it could rule, perhaps, but it could not mediate.

¹⁹On the Christological *imago* — Christ as the true image in whom human dignity and dominion are restored — see Eric Mattson, “Christ and the *Imago Dei*,” in *Restored to Our Destiny* (Leiden: Brill, 2012), DOI 10.1163/9789004207639_007; and the treatment of the image/glory locus in 2 Cor 3:18–4:6, “Paul and the Image of God” (2020), DOI 10.5040/9781978719637.ch-007.

²⁰Louis Berkhof, *Systematic Theology* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1938), on the person of Christ and the *munus triplex* (prophet, priest, king).

²¹B. B. Warfield, *The Person and Work of Christ* (Philadelphia: P&R, 1950), on the integrity of the two natures in the one person.

5d. Fellow Workers: We Are Not Replaced but Incorporated (1 Cor 3:9; John 15:5; Matt 28:18–20)

The decisive difference from the machine-messiah hope is what the true Steward does with the failed ones. He does not replace them; he incorporates them. “For we are God’s fellow workers” (1 Cor 3:9, ESV) — the redeemed are taken up into Christ’s own work, not retired from work. “I am the vine; you are the branches. Whoever abides in me and I in him, he it is that bears much fruit, for apart from me you can do nothing” (John 15:5, ESV) — the steward’s work is neither autonomous (the Babel error) nor abolished (the abdication error) but *derivative and real*: real fruit, borne by the branch, sourced in the vine. And the cultural mandate of Paper 1 is not retired but recommissioned: the Great Commission — “Go therefore and make disciples of all nations... teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you” (Matt 28:19–20, ESV) — takes up the cultivate-and-keep mandate into the mission of the redeemed, who now labor *with* the true Steward in the world’s restoration.

This is the answer the machine-messiah hope cannot give. The machine, succeeding, would make the human redundant — its perfection would be the measure of the human’s obsolescence. The true Steward, succeeding, makes the human a *fellow worker* — his perfection is the source of the human’s restored vocation, not its retirement. Herman Bavinck’s treatment of the union with Christ as the heart of the application of redemption is the dogmatic frame: the believer’s work is the fruit of his union with the working Christ, real because Christ works in and through him, derivative because it is Christ’s work in him.²² The redeemed steward is neither the autonomous worker who needs no vine nor the abdicating non-worker who lets the vine work without him; he is the branch, bearing real fruit, apart from whom the steward can do nothing and in whom he can do what he is called to. The machine cannot offer this, because the machine cannot be a vine into which stewards are grafted; it can only be a tool stewards use or a sovereign to which they submit, and neither is

²²Herman Bavinck, *Reformed Dogmatics*, vol. 4: *Holy Spirit, Church, and New Creation*, ed. John Bolt, trans. John Vriend (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2008), on the application of redemption (the *ordo salutis*) and union with Christ as the ground of the believer’s fruit-bearing work.

the fellow-working union the gospel gives.

5e. The Guardrail's Ground: The One Steward Without Sin

The series guardrail — providence through flawed stewards — finds its ground here, and the finding is the arc's quiet climax. Abraham sinned and the promise held; Moses sinned and the deliverance held; David sinned and the covenant held. The pattern has been insisted on at every stage, and the question it raises is finally answered at the Christ stage: *why* did the promise hold across the stewards' failures? Not because the failures were small — they were grave — and not because God overlooks sin, which he does not. The promise held because it was secured, from the first, by the faithfulness of a coming Steward who would *not* fail — the one to whom all the flawed stewards pointed, whose perfect obedience is the ground on which their imperfect stewardship was carried. The flawed stewards were upheld not in spite of needing a perfect one but *because* the perfect one was promised and coming; their failures, borne by God's patience, were always oriented toward the Steward who would bear them away. The machine-messiah hope reads the flawed stewards as the reason to build a successor; the gospel reads them as the promise of a Savior — and the Savior, when he comes, is not their replacement but their redemption, the sinless Human in whom their stewardship, and ours, is taken up and made to stand.

§6. The Framework: HGC³AE² Fulfilled and Recommissioned in Christ

The framework thread the series has carried lands, at the Christ stage, on its fulfillment. Human Governance and Curation — the imago-Dei steward as the governing status over autonomy — is shown to be neither a human achievement nor a human pretension but a vocation *fulfilled in Christ and recommissioned to the redeemed in him*. The true governor has come; he governs rightly; and he incorporates the redeemed into his governance as fellow workers, so that the human governing office, far from being abolished by the perfect Steward, is established and dignified by him.

The framework's central claim against the machine — that the human governs the autonomous system rather than defers to it — receives at this stage its deepest ground. The human governs not

by superior capability (the machine surpasses him), not merely by accountability (Paper 2) or given skill (Paper 5) or subjecthood (Paper 6), but because the governing office is *Christ's*, conferred on the redeemed as those united to the true Governor and made his fellow workers. The machine cannot occupy this office, not because it lacks capability but because it is not in Christ — it is not a redeemed human incorporated into the Steward's perfect stewardship, and the office is, finally, a participation in *his*. The machine-messiah hope wanted a perfect governor and proposed to build one; the gospel announces that the perfect Governor has come, that he is the true Human, and that he governs not by replacing the human stewards but by redeeming them into his own reign. The design rule for the autonomous age is, at the last, Christological: the human governs the machine as a fellow worker of the true Steward, holding the powerful instrument within the mandate Christ has recommissioned, neither abdicating the office to the machine nor seizing it as Babel — bearing real fruit as the branch, apart from the vine able to do nothing.

The recommissioned mandate is oriented, finally, toward a consummation the framework only anticipates. G. K. Beale's biblical theology reads the whole canon as the unfolding of the new creation inaugurated in Christ and awaiting its fullness — the already-not-yet in which the redeemed labor with the true Steward toward an end he has secured but not yet completed.²³ The human governing office, on this reading, is neither abolished nor self-sufficient but eschatological: exercised now as fellow work with the risen Christ, completed only when the new creation is consummated. The machine has no place in that arc except as a tool the fellow workers wield, because it is not united to the Steward whose reign the arc fulfills.

6a. A Governed Convergence: The Machine as Reconstructed Messiah

One body of secular scholarship has surfaced, on its own terms, a structural fact the doctrine already holds, and the series' signature permits naming it — once, subordinately, with the seam kept honest. Robert Geraci's study *Apocalyptic AI* documented, from within religious studies and with

²³G. K. Beale, *A New Testament Biblical Theology: The Unfolding of the Old Testament in the New* (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2011), on the already-not-yet and the new creation toward which the recommissioned mandate moves.

no apologetic motive, that the discourse of advanced artificial intelligence and robotics reconstructs with striking fidelity the structure of apocalyptic and messianic religion: a coming superintelligence cast as savior, a transcendent digital future cast as heaven, the present moment cast as the eve of a salvific transformation.²⁴ The finding, reached for descriptive and analytical reasons, is that the machine-messiah hope is not a departure from religion but a *reconstruction* of it — the messianic longing reasserting itself and projecting its object onto the machine.

The convergence with the inverted-creation reading is exact, and the seam must be kept honest. The religious-studies scholar reached this fact analytically: he found that the longing for a savior reasserts itself in the technical discourse and attaches to the coming machine. The doctrine names the ground the discipline cannot reach: that the messianic longing is *true* — there is a perfect Steward and the human heart is right to long for him — but that its object is mistaken, because the true Messiah has already come, as the Human and not the machine. The discipline establishes the structural fact — *the messianic longing reasserts itself and seeks a savior in the machine* — and the doctrine supplies its meaning — *the longing is the image of God in the creature reaching for the Steward it was made for, and the Steward has come, in flesh and not in silicon*. The convergence corroborates; it does not carry the beat. And it sharpens the whole paper's claim: even on the secular scholar's own showing, the machine-messiah hope is a displaced religious longing — and the gospel announces the un-displaced object of that longing, the true and faithful Steward who is the Human the machine can never be.

§7. *What Falls Out*

Several applied consequences follow, bearing on the domains the series has named and bringing the arc to its landing.

For **technology**, the Christ stage supplies the final design rule: the machine is to be received as a tool held within the mandate the true Steward has recommissioned, never as the messiah the heart is

²⁴Geraci, *Apocalyptic AI*. The reconstruction of messianic-apocalyptic religious structure within advanced-AI discourse is the load-bearing point of the R11 convergence beat.

tempted to make it. The most powerful system is still an instrument in the hands of fellow workers of Christ; to look to it as savior or sovereign is to seek a messiah in the creature, the idolatry the series has tracked from Babel, in its final and most exalted form. The test of the autonomous age is whether the human holds the machine as a tool under the true Steward, or bows to it as the steward it can never be.

For **work**, the stage establishes the dignity and the limit of all redeemed labor: it is real (the branch bears fruit), and it is derivative (apart from the vine, nothing). The fellow-worker frame is the cure for both the Babel pride that makes work self-glory and the abdication despair that surrenders work to the machine: the redeemed steward works neither autonomously nor not-at-all but *with Christ*, and the worth of his work is secured by the union, not by its surpassing the machine's output. The displaced worker of Paper 3, the builder of Paper 4, the craftsman of Paper 5, the psalmist of Paper 6 — each is, in Christ, a fellow worker whose labor is taken up into the true Steward's perfect work.

For **family and church**, the Great Commission recommissions the cultural mandate: the redeemed community labors with Christ in the world's restoration, making disciples, cultivating and keeping, building and planting, as fellow workers of the Steward who has all authority. The church's witness in the machine-messiah age is the announcement that the perfect Steward has come — not as the successor that abolishes the human, but as the Human that redeems the rest — and the invitation to be grafted into his reign as fellow workers rather than to await a silicon savior who can rule but cannot redeem.

The seven-problem spine is brought to its landing. Grounding (#1) is closed in Christ: human worth rests on the God who became human, unrevokable by any capability. Displacement (#2) is answered at its root: the perfect Steward is the true Human, vindicating and not superseding humanity. The unit of analysis (#3) bit decisively: Christ defines the person — the human is what the incarnate Son assumed, not a property-list a machine could satisfy. Vocation (#4) is fulfilled and recommissioned: the true Worker does the work and makes us fellow workers. Dignity-distribution (#5), featured here, is closed: dignity is conferred through the incarnation, beyond capability's reach. Governance

(#6), featured here, is fulfilled: the true Governor has come, good not by external alignment but in himself, and he incorporates the redeemed into his reign. And the driver, Purpose / End (#7), lands: the human is *for* communion with God and fellow-working in his redemptive purpose — a purpose disclosed and accomplished in Christ, and awaiting only its consummation in the new creation, where the arc opened at the first paper will be closed in full.

§8. Conclusion

The series opened with the human as the *imago Dei*, a created creator commissioned to steward, and a seven-problem set whose seventh question — what is the human *for*? — was left open as the driver. This paper has argued that the question is answered in Jesus Christ, the true and faithful Steward, in whom creation is inverted for the creature's recovery: the Image takes the creature's form (Col 1:15; John 1:14), the One who was God does not grasp but empties himself (Phil 2:6–7), and the second Adam's obedience cascades up to make the many righteous (Rom 5:19). The contemporary frame the paper answered is the machine-messiah hope — the longing, true in its ache and false in its object, for a perfect artificial steward to replace the human stewards who failed. Against it the gospel announces that the perfect Steward has come, and he is the Human and not the machine; that he does not replace the failed stewards but redeems them; that he governs as the true Governor, good in himself and not by imposed alignment; and that he makes the redeemed his fellow workers, recommissioning the cultural mandate in the Great Commission. The series guardrail found its ground: the flawed stewards were upheld across their failures because the sinless Steward was promised and coming, and when he came he was their redemption and not their replacement.

The machine can govern but cannot redeem; can rule but cannot represent; can be made powerful but cannot be made good in itself; can reconstruct the messianic hope but cannot be its object. The true and faithful Steward has done the work perfectly, and he calls the human not into obsolescence but into fellow-working — the branch in the vine, apart from whom we can do nothing and in whom we bear much fruit. The circle creation opened, Christ has closed; and what remains — the consummation in which the redeemed reign with him and the new creation receives the glory of

the nations — is the not-yet toward which this arc points and which the series, beyond this paper, will trace to its end. The human was never the candidate for replacement. He was always the one for whom the true Steward would come — and he has come.

Footnotes

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[Reformed-slate completion at v0.2: weave Calvin (Christ as the image in whom ours is restored), Hoekema (Christ-as-true-image chapter of *Created in God's Image*), Berkhof, Murray (imputation),

Vos and Beale (already in the series) as load-bearing. This paper inherits the DOI-verified P7 sourcing pass (p7-sourcing-pass.md, re-slugged from p3- on 2026-05-31); source floor is closer to met than P3–P6 but the citation-honesty audit + Reformed weave remain. See work product.]*